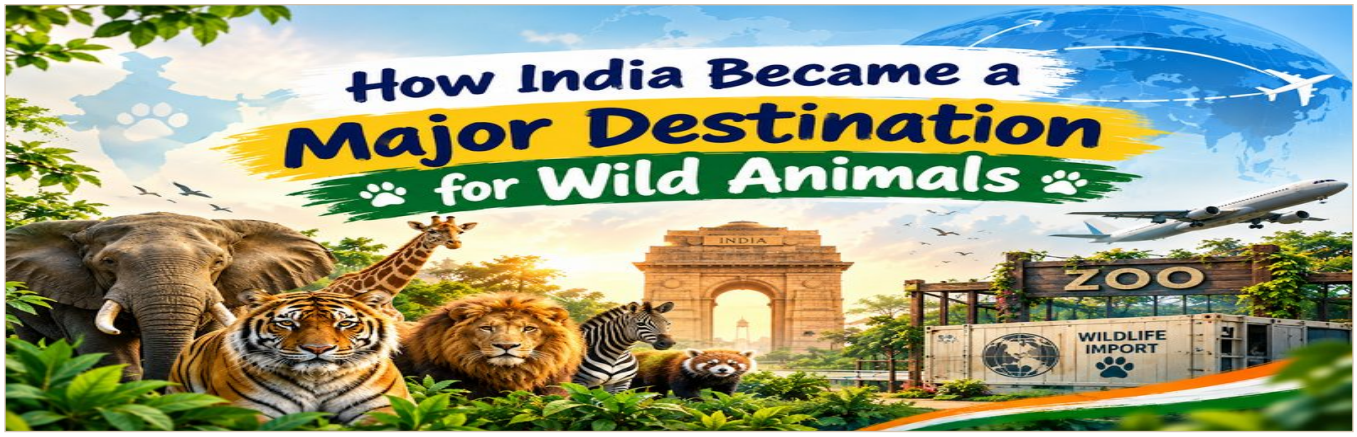


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# How India Became a Major Destination for Wild Animals




*Explore why India has emerged as a major destination for international wildlife imports, particularly for zoos and captive conservation facilities. Understand the UPSC relevance through **CITES, wildlife trade, ex-situ conservation, animal welfare, and India's regulatory framework**.*

## How India Became a Major Destination for Wild Animals

## Syllabus relevance:

**GS Paper III – Environment & Ecology**

A report titled **"How India became No.1 destination for wild animals"** highlighted the growing movement of wild animals from different countries into India, particularly for **zoos and captive facilities**. The report points to a sharp rise in the number and diversity of animals entering Indian zoological institutions in recent years. Importantly, the phrase "No.1 destination" refers to **international movement/import of animals for zoos and related purposes**, and not to natural migration of wild animals into India.

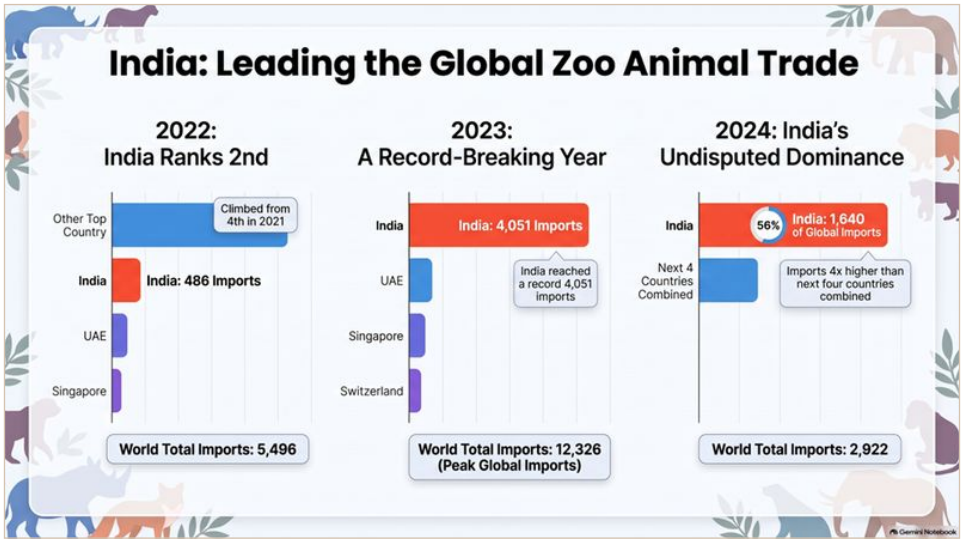


## 1. Why are wild animals brought to India?

International movement of animals may take place for several legitimate purposes:

- **Conservation breeding programmes**
- Exchange between zoological institutions
- Scientific research and education
- Genetic management of captive populations
- Rescue and rehabilitation
- Development of recognised zoological facilities
- Species restoration and reintroduction programmes

However, importing animals also requires adequate **veterinary facilities, quarantine arrangements, suitable habitats, trained personnel and long-term financial resources**.




## 2. CITES – The Key International Framework

The **Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora (CITES)** regulates international trade in wild animals and plants so that such trade does not threaten their survival.

CITES classifies species into three Appendices:

**Appendix I:** Species threatened with extinction; international commercial trade is generally prohibited.

**Appendix II:** Species that may become threatened unless trade is regulated; controlled international trade is permitted.

**Appendix III:** Species protected in at least one country that seeks cooperation from other countries to control trade.

India is a Party to CITES, and its international wildlife-trade framework operates through domestic legislation and regulatory authorities.

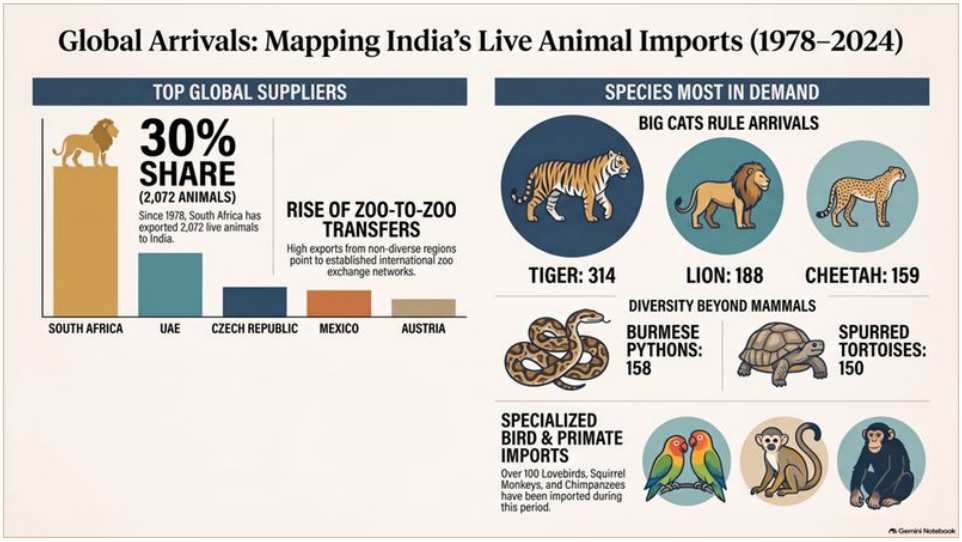
## 3. India's Legal and Institutional Framework

The **Wild Life (Protection) Act, 1972** is the principal legislation for wildlife protection in India. International wildlife trade is also linked with the **Customs Act, 1962** and the **Foreign Trade (Development and Regulation) Act, 1992**.

Important institutions include:

- **Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC)** – overall policy framework
- **Central Zoo Authority (CZA)** – regulation and standards relating to zoos
- **Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB)** – prevention and enforcement against wildlife crime
- **Directorate of Wildlife Preservation** – important role in implementation of CITES-related controls
- **Customs authorities** – regulation and detection of illegal wildlife movement at international borders

The CZA also deals with zoo animal exchanges, subject to the required clearances and CITES permits.




## 4. Ex-situ vs In-situ Conservation

**In-situ conservation** means conserving species in their natural habitats, such as national parks, wildlife sanctuaries and biosphere reserves.

**Ex-situ conservation** involves conservation outside the natural habitat, including:

- Zoos
- Captive-breeding centres
- Gene banks
- Botanical gardens

Zoos can contribute to conservation breeding, public awareness and scientific research. However, captive conservation cannot completely replace protection of species in their natural ecosystems.

## 5. Conservation vs. Wildlife Trade

The increasing movement of animals across borders raises an important governance question: **When does movement of wildlife serve conservation, and when can it become commercial exploitation or contribute to illegal trade?**

Key concerns include:

- Animal welfare and quality of captivity
- Disease transmission and quarantine
- Genetic diversity of captive populations
- Availability of suitable enclosures and veterinary care
- Transparency in international animal transfers
- Risk of illegal wildlife trafficking
- Whether imports produce measurable conservation benefits

CITES itself distinguishes between regulated legal trade and illegal wildlife trafficking. India has also strengthened enforcement against wildlife crime through agencies such as the WCCB.




## 6. Do Not Confuse Zoo Imports with Project Cheetah

**zoo imports** and **conservation translocation**.

Under **Project Cheetah**, eight cheetahs were brought from Namibia and released in Kuno National Park on **17 September 2022**. Twelve more were subsequently translocated from South Africa in February 2023. The project aims at restoring a species that had become extinct in India and rebuilding a free-ranging population.

Therefore:

## Zoo import !' captive management/ex-situ purposes

## Conservation translocation !' restoration or establishment of wild populations

## Wildlife trafficking !' illegal movement or trade

India's growing role in the international movement of wild animals highlights the intersection of **biodiversity conservation, international wildlife trade, CITES, animal welfare and environmental governance**. For UPSC preparation, the focus should therefore be on the **regulatory framework, conservation objectives and challenges associated with transboundary wildlife movement**, rather than simply memorising import numbers.